ask. The Sangh itself is on a gradual restructuring exercise, with younger pracharaks being handed more responsibilities and assignments. It would be in the BJP's interest that Nabin and the Sangh leadership work to make the party more relevant to this cohort.

Nabin's next challenge will be managing the broad coalition of the old and new guard in the party, those who cut their teeth under Vajpayee and Advani, like Rajnath Singh, Shivraj Chouhan and Vasundhara Raje, and those who grew to prominence during the Modi years, like Yogi Adityanath, Devendra Fadnavis, Himanta Biswa Sarma, Dharmendra Pradhan and others. Nabin must navigate a generational overlap too. At 45, he's a decade younger than most Union cabinet ministers (average age: 58.7 years) and state unit chiefs (average age: 54). Senior leaders command their own loyal constituencies. The BJP's strength, a top party leader argues, has always been its ability to absorb leaders without fracturing. Balancing the aspirations of his contemporaries will be no easy task. They, too, are now desirous of larger roles, either in the national team or the respective state units and government.

CADRE AND COMPLACENCY

It's a strange situation: after a decade in power, the BJP's biggest challenge is not from the Opposition, but from complacency. The party's cadre, its true engine, has begun showing signs of exhaustion. Booth-level workers, who once campaigned with missionary zeal, now expect rewards, visibility and recognition. Nabin's mandate will be to reignite this fading spark. His maiden speech as party president also stressed on this.

Geographically, too, the BJP's dominance hides a few fragilities. It remains formidable across the Hindi heartland, but is yet to crack the deeper South or consolidate in parts of the East. Nabin's Bihar origins give him credibility in the North and East, but expanding the BJP's organisational depth in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh along with Punjab will need innovation beyond Hindutva and Modi charisma. It will mean cultivating the local leadership, new allies and cultural idioms that speak to regional pride.

The politics of coalition, too, has returned centre stage. The BJP, which once sought to swim alone, is now learning to govern in partnership again. From Nitish Kumar in Bihar to Chandrababu Naidu in Andhra Pradesh, allies have regained leverage. Party insiders say Nabin must master the art of accommodation, balancing firmness with flexibility, persuasion with respect. Nabin seems to have the right mindset here. Colleagues from Bihar tell INDIA TODAY that he has always kept the party's interests above his own. "It's a quality that has won him friends across party lines in Bihar...a trait he has inherited from his father, the late BJP veteran Nabin Kishore Sinha," says one of them.

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- **Assembly polls in April-May in four crucial states, with West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala traditionally weak spots for BJP**
- **In the top-heavy party that is BJP, Nabin has to be assertive while managing the expectations of both Modi-Shah duo and Sangh**
- **He must manage aspirations of old guard and new. Being youngest in the room may not be a plus**
- **A decade into power, complacency has set in. Cadre is not as motivated**

Nabin's Bihar colleagues say he has always kept the party's interests above his own. "It's a quality that has won him friends across party lines..."

LOOKING FORWARD

Equally important is the relationship between party and government. Under Modi, the government has often overshadowed the BJP's organisational voice. After the 2024 general election, even the Sangh has been asking for a more robust feedback mechanism—seen inside the party as a way to prepare it for the post-Modi era. Dovetailed to this process, Nabin's tenure will also be judged by how he restores the BJP's image as an ideological force, and not just as a vehicle of governance. So the Sangh leadership will be watching closely. Nabin's ability to reconnect with their grassroots ethos, from 'swadeshi economics' to 'civilisational self-confidence', could define his presidency.

Beneath all this lies the question that lurks unspoken under every conversation in Delhi's corridors—what comes after Modi? The PM remains the BJP's unmatched vote-getter, but the party knows that leadership changes are inevitable. Nabin's big contribution may be to anchor a smooth generational transition, to begin grooming the next set of national leaders without threatening the existing order.

Nabin inherits the world's most formidable political machine—well-funded, disciplined and ideologically anchored—but one that must evolve to sustain its dominance. This presidency may not be about how Nitin Nabin leads the party to its next election, but about how he prepares it for its next generation. The BJP, which once prided itself on being a "party with a difference", is at an inflection point again. ■